

NOT HIS LOOM
Ahtisham Hussain abandoned the fine art of weaving pashminas. He now works at a sanitary warehouse



STILL STANDING
Rauf Ahmad Qureshi works on a loom at his house in Srinagar

crore in 2021. While officials blame the pandemic for the precipitous drop, exporters and artisans point to a more insidious foe: machine-made products sold as 'genuine' Kashmir handicrafts. Thus, an ersatz 'Pashmina shawl' made on a machine and priced at Rs 3,000 is sold to unsuspecting customers, devaluing the Pashmina brand. According to businessmen, overseas clients now test the product in laboratories for genuineness. Mill-made products have also put many craftsmen—from women who would convert fibres into fine yarn on a *charkha* (spinning wheel) to weavers—out of jobs.

Rauf Ahmad Qureshi, founder, Kashmir Pashmina Karigar Union, who still uses women workers for producing handmade shawls, says machines have ruined their trade. "One machine spindle spins 200 grams of Pashmina fibre a day or more, with 10-20 per cent nylon. Its yarn is cheap, costing Rs 8,000 to Rs 20,000 a kg," he says. But the thread/ yarn produced from the wool on a traditional *charkha*, says Qureshi, is 100 per cent pure and priced at Rs 40,000-50,000 a kg. "The yarn produced on spinners is woven on power looms with a capacity to make 100 shawls a day. It's sold as 'Kashmir Pashmina', threatening our legacy. They should have a machine-made label to avoid cheating clients," he says. The union has been asking authorities to shut illegal machines and to help promote national and international awareness of the GI (Geographical Indication) tag that was secured for Pashmina products in 2008.

Since a GI tag identifies a unique product of a region, its enforcement is expected to weed out counterfeits. The products will be tested in a laboratory and genuine items will be labelled with a Radio Frequency Identification (RFID) tag. Seven Kashmir handicrafts have secured a GI, including Pashmina, walnut wood carving, papier mache craft, sozni craft, kani shawl, carpets and Khatamband.

Rauf Wadera, consultant with Tahafuzz, an organisation representing Kashmiri artisans, says the recognition has enabled greater entry into global markets. But now, the key concern should be providing artisans with social and economic security. "A separate labour protection policy should be there to ensure minimum wages for artisans," he says. "A benevolent fund for contingency needs, health insurance, provision for children's education and supply of raw materials at a fair price are also needed."

President of the Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industry (KCCI) Sheikh Ashiq was amongst Kashmiri business leaders who met Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi on April 5. He submitted a memorandum seeking exemption of taxes on all handicraft products. His proposals include setting up special production centres to push the industry towards being an organised sector and thus improve the lot of artisans.

Tariq Ahmad Zargar, director, handicrafts and handlooms Kashmir, says artisans are benefitting from the Karkhandar scheme, launched in 2021, that aims to revive languishing crafts through improving artisans' skills and inculcating a spirit of entrepreneurship in them. The government has incentivised the programme by offering Rs 2,000 a month to each trainee artisan. Later, each qualified artisan is paid Rs 50,000 in two instalments. "We are working on branding, packaging and introduction of new designs for international market requirements. Besides, we are concentrating on access to new markets, especially the US, which remains untapped," says Zargar.

Hopefully, the scheme would stop some of the world's finest craftsmen from being forced to relinquish their trade due to sheer want. ■